# DCTVU

## DC TELEVISION UNIVERSE

Franchise Bible — Volume 12: The Drought (and the Exception)

**FORMAT • TONE • CONTINUITY • CANON • TEAMS & FOUNDING ROSTERS**

An alternate-history story told through Hollywood trades, headlines,
social media, the internet, and screenplay-format scenes.

Story present: 2010.
Six live-action series + two animated series. One multiverse.

Internal development document. Fictional actors and the individual series to be created in later volumes.

# The Drought of 2010

As 2010 begins, eleven gifted young actors can't book a steady job anywhere in Hollywood. They aren't short on talent. They're boxed in by **four walls** they can't see, and then hit by personal disasters on top of that. Only one of them is working nonstop: **Marc-Anthony Bullock**, for a completely different reason (Section 3).

# Section 1 — The Four Walls

| Wall | What it is | Who it traps |
|---|---|---|
| **1. The Gus Rule** (Donohue) | Since 1923, Donohue has refused to hire the family or household of its sitting CEO, so no one can claim favoritism. When Natasha became CEO on Oct. 1, 2006, the rule kicked in for her circle. Existing contracts were honored until they ran out, and the last of them ended in 2009. The policy is admirable, and it shuts the family out of the biggest employer in entertainment. | Elxa, Grace, Amond (who lives with the family half the time and is counted as household), and Marc-Anthony (see Section 3) |
| **2. The Federal Monitor** (Washington) | Under a 1997 Justice Department consent decree over Donohue's market dominance, any company that does business with Donohue must get a federal monitor's approval before paying any Donohue family member. Nearly every company in the world does business with Donohue. Reviews take 6 to 14 months, and most producers give up long before then. | Elxa, Grace, Marc-Anthony |
| **3. The Smilley Blacklist** (Crownstone) | Since the defection of Mar. 1, 2007, Charles Smilley has kept an unwritten list. Anyone who left Nickelodeon with Marc-Anthony, works closely with him, or is close to the Bullocks doesn't get hired at Crownstone Pictures, Nickelodeon, MTV, BET, Comedy Central, CBS, or Showtime. Through CBS, it also reaches half of The CW. Nothing is ever written down, and every casting director in town knows about it. | Tayia, Amond, Tyler, the Bullock sisters, and anyone who shows up at Marc-Anthony's parties |
| **4. The Crossfire** (everyone else) | Warner Bros., Universal, Sony, Fox, and Lionsgate want no part of a war between the Mouse and the Crown, and neither do the independents. Their unofficial policy: *"Don't hire anyone either side might be mad about."* | Everyone listed above |

## And the real world piled on

- **The 2007–08 writers' strike** (Nov. 5, 2007 – Feb. 12, 2008) wiped out a pilot season and left studios with fewer scripted shows.
- **The SAG contract standoff** (the actors' contract expired June 30, 2008, and a new one wasn't ratified until June 9, 2009) made studios afraid to start new films.
- **The 2008 financial crisis** dried up independent film money, and studio slates were cut by a third.
- **DVD sales collapsed**, ending the mid-budget movies young actors usually graduate into.
- **Reality TV took over** prime-time slots that used to go to scripted dramas.

# The Grey's Exception: Natasha Is Her Own Boss

> *Grey's Anatomy* airs on **ABC** and is made by **ABC Studios**, both owned by Donohue. That makes Natasha Bullock the CEO of the company that employs Dr. Miranda Bailey, who is also Natasha Bullock. On set she takes notes from the show's creator, Shonda Rhimes; in Burbank she's the boss above Shonda's bosses.

- **She's covered by the exception her kids lost.** Natasha was cast in March 2005 and became CEO on Oct. 1, 2006, so the Gus Rule doesn't apply to her *Grey's* contract. Her children's old contracts ran out in 2009, and they're shut out, while their mother keeps working on her own network.
- **She steps aside on her own deal.** At every contract renewal, Natasha leaves the boardroom. Victor, as chairman, and the board handle it, and the federal monitor reviews her pay like anyone else's in the family.
- **The hypocrisy line:** Charles Smilley uses it in the trades: *"Donohue blocks the CEO's children to prevent favoritism, while the CEO stars on her own network."*
- **Inside the family:** Elxa and Grace have noticed. Marc-Anthony turns it into material.

## Scene — "Insubordination"

**Sunday, January 10, 2010, 7:18 PM PT. The Donohue estate, Bel Air.** Natasha Bullock (38), Marc-Anthony Bullock (18), Elxa Bullock (19), Grace Bullock (15), Robert Bullock (40), Victor Donohue (63), Joan Donohue (61).

**INT. DONOHUE ESTATE — FORMAL DINING ROOM — NIGHT**

Sunday dinner. Long table, good china, nobody using it correctly. NATASHA, 38, still in Bailey's scrubs under a cashmere wrap, comes in late, reading a script on her phone.

NATASHA

Don't start. We went long. Shonda added a scene.

GRACE

(sweetly)

Must be nice. Having a job.

ELXA

On a network. That your family owns. That won't hire your family.

NATASHA

I was cast before I was CEO. It's grandfathered.

VICTOR

(not looking up from his plate)

She's grandfathered. I'm the grandfather. It's a whole system.

MARC-ANTHONY, 18, sets down his fork and turns to the table like it's a sold-out arena.

MARC-ANTHONY

Y'all. Y'all. My mother is the only woman in America who can call in sick to herself, deny it, and then write herself up

for insubordination.

GRACE chokes on her water. ELXA puts her head down on the table. ROBERT, 40, tries to hold it together and fails. Even JOAN, 61, covers her mouth.

MARC-ANTHONY (CONT'D)

She has to leave the room to negotiate with herself. She sits in the hallway like, “I hope she gives me a raise. She's a lot.”

NATASHA

(dead calm, cutting her steak)

Keep going. I can't hire you, but I can still ground you.

MARC-ANTHONY

Can you, though? Legally? I'd need the federal monitor to review that.

Victor finally laughs, one short bark. Natasha points her knife at him.

NATASHA

Don't encourage him.

VICTOR

Baby, I was running this company when you were in kindergarten. I know a good joke about it when I hear one.

Under the table, Grace and Marc-Anthony bump fists. Natasha sees it, and almost smiles.

**CUT TO:**

# Section 2 — Eleven Droughts

## AMOND BAKER

| | |
|---|---|
| Age (Jan. 1, 2010) | 17 (turns 18 on Feb. 10, 2010) |
| Walls | The Gus Rule (counted as household), the Smilley Blacklist, the Crossfire |
| The personal disaster | In August 2009 his agency, Pinnacle Talent, collapsed when its founder was arrested for running a $340 million Ponzi scheme on its clients. Amond's contracts, back pay, and future representation rights are frozen in federal bankruptcy court, and he can't sign with a new agent until a judge releases him, with a hearing set for **Nov. 2010**. On top of that, he grew **seven inches in 2009**: too tall for kids' roles and still too young-looking for adult ones. |
| 2010 reality | Zero bookings, and waiting tables at a Culver City diner, where his manager says the tips are better than the residuals. |
| What ends it | Green Arrow, 2012 |

## TYRESE AVERY

| | |
|---|---|
| Age (Jan. 1, 2010) | 18 (turns 19 on July 24, 2010) |
| Walls | The Crossfire, plus his own fame |
| The personal disaster | In 2009 he signed a **$400 million world-tour contract: 280 shows in 41 countries from 2009 to 2012**, which leaves no time to shoot a film. Then in October 2009 he fell 14 feet through a stage trapdoor in São Paulo. He recovered fully, but film insurers now refuse to cover any production with him, and without insurance no studio can start shooting. Add the bad reviews for *Midnight Shift*, and Hollywood's verdict is that he's uninsurable and can't act. |
| 2010 reality | Sells out stadiums every night and can't get an acting audition. |
| What ends it | The tour ends early in 2015; he's cast as Hawkman that year |

## ESTHER SMILLEY

| | |
|---|---|
| Age (Jan. 1, 2010) | 17 (turns 18 on Sept. 20, 2010) |
| Walls | Her own family |
| The personal disaster | As a minor, Esther can't sign anything without her parents' approval, and her parents are also her managers. Since “coming home” to Crownstone in 2009, Vivian has **turned down 147 scripts**, a record her agents keep in a binder. Charles has shelved the two Crownstone films she was cast in, worried they would “age her too fast.” When she turns 18 on **Sept. 20, 2010**, she can sign for herself, but the Crossfire means no other studio will take Charles Smilley's daughter away from him. |
| 2010 reality | America's sweetheart, with an empty calendar and the most famous unused talent in town. |
| What ends it | Wonder Woman on CBS in 2015, the one role her father couldn't say no to |

## ARIANNA CUMMINGS

| | |
|---|---|
| Age (Jan. 1, 2010) | 17 (turns 18 on Oct. 25, 2010) |
| Walls | The Crossfire, and disappearing paperwork |
| The personal disaster | *Bronzeville*, the Sundance film that should have made her a star, was bought in January 2009 by **Crownstone Vantage**, the studio's specialty-film label. Crownstone then shut the label down, as Paramount did with its Vantage label in real life. The film's rights are stuck in the shutdown, and it can't be released, sold, or even screened for casting directors. Her career-defining performance is locked away. Then her agent retired, and his assistant lost her file. |
| 2010 reality | Critics call her the best young actress nobody's seen. She's working at a Chicago box office. |
| What ends it | Hawkgirl, 2015 |

## HARMONY DIVINE

| | |
|---|---|
| Age (Jan. 1, 2010) | 17 (turns 18 on June 19, 2010) |
| Walls | The Crossfire, and a contract trap |
| The personal disaster | At 16 she signed a **seven-year option deal** with Crownstone's MTV Films for a planned dance-movie franchise called *Step Into It*. The studio can keep her under contract simply by renewing the option every year, which it has, without ever making the movie. The deal bans her from appearing in any other feature film. Crownstone has no intention of making the film, and it isn't letting her go either. |
| 2010 reality | Legally barred from movies, she's auditioning for TV guest spots, where casting directors only see her as a dancer. |
| What ends it | Iris West, 2014, once the option expires and her lawyers win |

## TYLER CHAPMAN

| | |
|---|---|
| Age (Jan. 1, 2010) | 17 (turns 18 on Jan. 4, 2010) |
| Walls | The Smilley Blacklist, and a legal trap |
| The personal disaster | His *Garage Band* contract included a Nick Records deal that **trademarked "Tyler Chapman" as a Viacom brand name through 2012**. He legally can't perform, act, or release music under his own name anywhere else. Then on Jan. 5, 2010, the day after his own 18th birthday, he's photographed at Marc-Anthony's 18th birthday party, and he goes on the Blacklist. |
| 2010 reality | An actor who can't legally use his own name. |
| What ends it | The trademark expires in 2012; he's cast as the Reverse-Flash in 2014 |

## DAVID TIPTON

| | |
|---|---|
| Age (Jan. 1, 2010) | 19 (turns 20 on Nov. 14, 2010) |
| Walls | The Crossfire, and a case of mistaken identity |
| The personal disaster | A casting database mistakenly **merged his records with those of a different David Tipton from Houston who has a felony record**. Every background check and insurance screening flags him. He has spent 14 months and $9,000 he doesn't have trying to clear his name. At 6'4", he's also “too tall for the leading ladies,” and his old knee injury scares insurers. |
| 2010 reality | Working the front desk at a Burbank gym, cast in nothing. |
| What ends it | The record is cleared in 2011; he's cast as Black Adam in 2016 |

## TAYIA BOYD

| | |
|---|---|
| Age (Jan. 1, 2010) | 17 (turns 18 on Feb. 3, 2010) |
| Walls | The Smilley Blacklist (high on it), the Crossfire |
| The personal disaster | She left Nickelodeon with Marc-Anthony in 2007, so to Charles she's the second defector. Then the first Broadway musical she starred in lost its funding in September 2008, the week Lehman Brothers collapsed, when its lead investor went bankrupt. It closed in previews and left her with a reputation as “the girl from the show that never opened.” |
| 2010 reality | Typecast as the funny best friend, blacklisted at a third of the industry, and left with a closed Broadway show on her résumé. |
| What ends it | Black Canary, 2012 |

## ELXA BULLOCK

| | |
|---|---|
| Age (Jan. 1, 2010) | 19 (turns 20 on Aug. 29, 2010) |
| Walls | The Gus Rule, the Federal Monitor, the Smilley Blacklist, the Crossfire |
| The personal disaster | Her ABC Family talk show was protected by an existing contract until it ended in December 2009. Since then, every offer she has received is in federal review: the monitor reviewed one indie drama for 11 months, and its financing fell through. Producers outside the system won't hire “the Donohue princess,” afraid it will look like they're trying to buy Donohue's favor. |
| 2010 reality | The most famous unemployed host in America. |
| What ends it | Batwoman, 2019 |

## GRACE BULLOCK

| | |
|---|---|
| Age (Jan. 1, 2010) | 15 (turns 16 on Apr. 12, 2010) |
| Walls | The Gus Rule, the Federal Monitor, the Smilley Blacklist, the Crossfire |
| The personal disaster | *Gracie Goes Global* ended when her existing contract ran out in December 2009. California's child labor laws limit the hours a minor can work on set, and with the federal reviews on top, every production would need two separate approvals plus a studio teacher, and producers quit before they start. Her record label is a Donohue company, so her next album is blocked by the Gus Rule too. |
| 2010 reality | An award winner at 15 who can't book a guest spot. |
| What ends it | Donna Troy, 2017 |

## ELIJAH BLACKMAN

| | |
|---|---|
| Age (Jan. 1, 2010) | 15 (turns 16 on Mar. 23, 2010) |
| Walls | The Crossfire, and a family war |
| The personal disaster | His parents' bitter 2009 divorce left the court requiring **both parents' signatures on every contract**, and his trust account under California's Coogan Law is frozen until they agree. They haven't agreed on anything since 2008. Six offers, including *Space Cadets 3*, expired unsigned. And at 15 he still looks 12, so casting directors don't know what age to cast him as. |
| 2010 reality | A talented kid whose career is stuck in family court. |
| What ends it | He turns 18 in 2012 and signs for himself; he's cast as Billy Batson in 2017 |

# Section 3 — The Exception: Marc-Anthony Bullock

**Marc-Anthony has no dry spell.** All four walls apply to him too, and they don't stop him. His issue is the opposite of a drought: **he gets too many offers, and they're the wrong kind.**

- **He got around the Federal Monitor.** At 15, Marc-Anthony read the whole 412-page 1997 consent decree in one weekend and found a lawful way through it. He structures every deal through his own company, Hyperion Kid Productions, using a pre-approved arm's-length framework he drafted himself. The monitor approved it in 2008, and other monitored companies now copy it. Everyone else waits 6 to 14 months; Marc-Anthony gets cleared in **9 days**.
- **The Gus Rule doesn't reach his biggest contracts.** His Hollywood Records deal and his *Long Way Home* contract were signed in 2005, before Natasha became CEO, and they're honored through 2011. Everything new he does goes to other studios or he finances himself.
- **He's too big to blacklist.** Charles Smilley can keep Marc-Anthony out of Crownstone, but he can't keep him out of Warner, Universal, Sony, or Fox. Marc-Anthony brings in a huge built-in audience, so the studios that avoid everyone else in the Crossfire make an exception for him.
- **He works for himself.** He produces his own stand-up tours, music, and comedy specials and sells them worldwide. Nobody can cancel a man who owns his own work.
- **His 2010 calendar:** a lead role in a Universal comedy (shooting in spring 2010); the self-produced world stand-up tour *Marc-Anthony: Unsupervised* (42 cities); his second album, *Grown*; and a Golden Globe nomination for *The Long Way Home*. Of 412 offers in 2009, 389 were comedies.

## Why this hurts him

Marc-Anthony is the only one of his friends who is working, and he knows some of the walls are there *because of him*. He bends every rule he can to share his luck. He writes a clause into every new contract requiring the studio to audition at least two of his friends (the “Marc-Anthony Rider”). Studios sign it, hold the auditions, and never cast them. He secretly pays Amond's legal bills, and Amond finds out and is furious. He quietly gives Arianna's name to every director he works with. And he promises Tayia, Amond, and Grace the same thing on New Year's Eve 2009: *“I'm gonna build a door in every one of these walls. Y'all are walking through it with me.”*

He keeps that promise. In 2012, 2014, and 2015, the doors open one by one, in the DCTVU, at Warner Bros., the one studio big enough to stand up to the Mouse and the Crown.

**[Trade headline — Mon., Jan. 11, 2010]** “HOLLYWOOD'S LOST GENERATION: Why the Most Talented Kids in Town Can't Get Hired, and the One Who Can't Stop Working”